



6. *The Intentional and the Unintentional*

~~Theoretical simplifications in the nineteenth century attributed to the author either a precise conscious plan (well defined 'in the head' up to the smallest detail) or a messy net of idiosyncratic associations (over which s/he has no control).~~ What emerged in the end is the need for an author, for a real person who could be held *responsible* for the sense of writing, and could therefore confute inappropriate interpretations. The author shows up in interpretation well before biographies and in genetic comparisons: it is a matter of seeing *the result of human action* in literary and artistic works.

As we have seen, the first phase of approaches to the author implicitly postulated a hidden, interior intention that could not be reached by analyses. The 'real intentions' of writing were confined to an unreachable subjectivity, and the public aspects of writing were consequently belittled, given that they could not point to the hidden 'real intention' in the author. But, actually, in interpretation anything is better than nothing, and some indications about the author's intention have been recognized to be available and needed. If this is true, then it is better to build up an author *as best as we can*. A pragmatic approach to the author recognizes the fallibility of interpretation, but values all clues that can help to understand *intentions in the act of writing itself*, and so to see alternatives and choices in the words and sentences actually used.

The twentieth-century hunting season for the author showed above all that a *minimal* meaning attributed to a *minimal* author is very hard to find and define. On the other hand, the ends of speakers and writers do emerge from the historical and communicative context: they are not unavoidably lost after the author's physical death, because they never lived inside the author in the first place. Authors live in their works. There was in Dante no hidden *res*, there was no private 'real intention'; if there were one, then we would be justified to stop looking for it (given its disappearance), and only concentrate on language. But intention is public, and lives in the acts performed: it does not disappear, or all meaning would also disappear at the same time.¹⁰ Therefore, given (1) the need for an author, (2) the availability of intentions, (3) the difficulty in building a *minimal* author and meaning, then (4) we need to understand the author *as best as we can, by all means necessary*. Otherwise we would risk making the author say whatever we preferred. As a matter of fact,

whenever we build up a formal or minimal author, we are just projecting our intention into the text.¹¹ Referring to the author, on the other hand, permits us to evaluate the correctness of our interpretation.

Luigi Pareyson blamed Croce because for the latter the productive act had no value *per se*, and was only a means to express the universal idea behind the work. Pareyson had a very different theory about artistic creation: it is human action that gives artistic works their value, and 'it is necessary to consider art more as a "doing" than as an "expressing" or "contemplating"' (1974, 7; my translation). *The artistic intention emerges in interpretation*, and the interpreter needs to reactivate the author's intention in order to understand the work. Intentions are formed along the creative process and persist in the work's form. The matter is then how to understand the intentions of an author that make a work of art out of wood, or a piece of paper and some ink.

Umberto Eco elaborates on Pareyson's theory. Eco looks for an intention also in those *open works* whose meaning apparently does not depend on their author's project, either because random processes of creation played a major role in their production, or because the author left in them an ample space for interpretative freedom. Eco's theory is far from Barthes's and Derrida's ideas. For Eco, we need to look for and find an intention in order to recognize a work of art as such. Art, in other words, is *always intentional*, although some relevant parts of its expression and/or meaning can be left open to the interpreter's freedom. The author of an open work 'wanted to provoke a feeling of suspension, of indeterminateness' (1989, 116). Not all works of art are open works; but there is also an author's intention in open works: the intention to make an open work, in a certain way and for a certain end. Any work, 'even before becoming a field of actualizable choices, is already a field of actualized choices', and 'the original gesture, fixed by and in the sign, is in itself a direction that will eventually lead us to the discovery of the author's intention' (101-103). To interpret is then a matter of *cooperating with the author's intention*, as it is put into form in the work (Eco 1979).

For Barthes and Derrida the author's intention was a dull limit that the critic had to avoid, while Eco looks for an intention that is public (*intentio operis*, as in Eco 1990), and not 'in the head' of the author, defined up to the smallest detail before even taking up the pen (*intentio auctoris*).¹² This public intention leaves *some freedom* to the interpreter, an open field of possibilities, but not *complete freedom*. It may happen that a work does really escape from the author's control and begins to produce meaning by itself, but in that case 'what remains then is no longer a field of possibilities but rather the indistinct, the primary, the indeterminate at its wildest – at once everything and nothing' (1989, 93).

Eco's intention is perfectly compatible and complementary with Anscombe's. Intentions are semiotic realities, existing only within our public interpretation of actions and texts. Without intentions we could not give form to acts and texts (that are both the result of *intentional* activities), and intentions

are neither hidden *res* in the brain nor private experiences accessible only to oneself. Moreover, intentions can be (and for the later Eco *always are*, at least in part) open; whenever we act, our end is never defined up to the smallest detail, 'because *the intention itself was open*, aiming at a plural communication' (102; my emphasis). Openness is a property of language and of thought, depriving the will-to-say of the conscious perfection wanted by Husserl, but granting a partially-conscious directive power to it. We are not fully conscious of what we mean, whenever we speak or write, but we are conscious of at least *some* of the sense effects we want to obtain by speaking and writing.

The consequences of writing are only partially foreseen, and writers try to understand at their best the ways in which interpreters will read their works. This indeterminacy does not make our intentions less legitimate: that of a perfectly defined, 'crystalline closed' intended meaning in the mind is a wrong idea. What we think is analogous to what we write, with all the uncertainties and blank spaces (intentionally or not) left to the reader. Anscombe and Eco show that *intentions are public and open, against the two phenomenological 'myths' of a hidden interiority and of a perfect definition*. Barthes and Derrida could not recognize that *something* in the text is intentional and *something else* is not, otherwise they would have had to admit that the (however polysemic) author's intention remains in the text and in its interpretation. Anscombe and Eco actively look for clues to better interpretations and, when doing so, find an intention *at work*.

Thus, the later developments of twentieth-century reflection on subjectivity and language completely overturned the original statements about an 'intentional fallacy'. Interpretation is a matter of recognizing *what is intentional*: where the work begins and ends, and what is planned within it. There is also the need to recognize *what is unintentional*, above and beyond the author's intention – otherwise the author would become a god-like entity with a perfect control over language and with an unrealistically clear idea of the ends and consequences of his or her actions. In practice, while interpreting a text, *we need to distribute intended and non-intended messages*: the way in which we realize this distribution determines the resulting meaning. For example, it is very different to understand a certain sentence as ironic or not; it depends on how we give shape to the author's intention, on the basis of all the data we manage to find and to our reasoning. Attributing or not-attributing an intentional ironic message to a sentence depends on *the hypothesis we make about the author* (while the sentence itself remains the same in both readings). For example, to talk about our friend's mismatched socks can be done intentionally or not: it is all important to understand what is the case, in order to interpret the actual sense and use of what we say. And this applies also in case of intentional ambiguity.

This is the exact opposite of asserting that the author's intention is 'neither available nor desirable', as New Criticism suggested. Intention is always *at stake* and *in discussion*. The author cannot be exhausted, fully understood, because interpretation (from a pragmatic standpoint) is a nearly never-ending activity.

But *intention remains the only limit to interpretation* and the only possibility to negotiate our proper reading with others on a public basis. Intention is actually the opposite of what Husserl and the New Critics thought: intention is an entirely public benchmark, to be defined according to textual and contextual evidence against which diverse interpretations can be compared. Intention is public and visible, and not something hidden within the author. To be an author (and also to simply communicate) is a matter of publicly expressing something, and not at all keeping it private for oneself. There is nothing unreachable in communication, and especially not the author's intention.

I hope I have given an adequate idea of the richness and complexity of the debate on authorship and interpretation as it developed throughout the whole of the twentieth century. The subject, initially marginal, took a long time to become visible and describable. And every new idea of the author has been accompanied by a new idea of *what a text is*, and of how it should be read: realization of ideal meanings under the control of a transcendental subject; agglomerate of citations under the drives of the unconscious; intentional product of an author with a partially conscious strategy in mind. Only this last idea needs an effective, 'useful' concept of author: a person writing for an end, even if s/he may not be able to foresee all the consequences of his or her choices. This makes a *human* out of the author. In this way the word 'author' can be pronounced again without prefixes or restrictive attributions, without seeing in it the residual *par excellence*, that about which it is not possible to talk. There is no hidden author. A scapegoat for an entire century, the author is actually its dearest son, a linking of consciousness and the unconscious.

It was only following the twentieth-century debate that *the author was born*.

¹ This article presents some of the results of my PhD thesis, discussed at the University of Siena in May, 2010.

² Wimsatt and Beardsley (1954, 6) completely misunderstood Croce's theory and in particular ignored his 'golden rule' of dividing mundane intentions from the pure aesthetic intuition (see also Benedetti 1999, 41). Croce did not attribute the original formulation of the 'golden rule' to himself, but to the Italian critic Francesco De Sanctis and to Pëtr Kropotkin. New Criticism gave resonance to an approach that was well-known and recognized in nineteenth-century Europe.

³ Eric Hirsch proposes a form of intentionalism explicitly rooted in Husserl's phenomenology. Hirsch is only interested in meaning-intentions (*Bedeutungsintentionen*), and not in lived intentions (*Absichten*). From our perspective, Hirsch's position adds nothing to the 'intentional fallacy'. Hirsch's author is an ideal author (literary transposition of the transcendental subject), emptied of lived intentions, and fully aware of objective meanings independent from historical change: 'an unlimited number of intentional acts can intend the same verbal meaning' (1967, 38).

⁴ Important sources for the 'death of the Author' proposed by Barthes, and for French post-structuralism in general, are Lacan (1966) and Benveniste (1966).

⁵ Understanding the real extension of Barthes's 'death of the author' would require much more space than is allowed here. Let us simply say that it is not fully clear whether Barthes (1967) refers to *all* literary works, to *all contemporary* literary works, or to *some* contemporary literary works.

⁶ Foucault's move drastically changes the perspective in which we observe texts and authors. It is a matter of viewing authors as functions of texts, by which we 'build' and understand what we read. On the contrary, texts have been usually thought as 'signs' of the author's genius and creativity. As H.W. Gabler makes very clear in his contribution to the present volume, this revolution in perspective represents in a much better way how scholars actually deal with texts and promotes further effects in contemporary critical and interpretative practices. The concept of text itself emerges as a literate construction involving material documents on the one hand, and hypotheses about the author's work and will on the other.

⁷ Booth's author is *implied* and not *implicit*. Implied by the very existence of the text, as my coffee on the table implies that someone made it. Explicit and implicit messages are both to be referred to the author.

⁸ Actually, Foucault's position can be interpreted as saying that the ordinary concept of author has to be *substituted* by the author-function, meaning that there is no hidden 'real author' but only an effective semiotic figure built by discourses. This interpretation would imply that Foucault also held that the author function manifests *all* of the author's intention and 'interiority', as Elisabeth Anscombe more explicitly stated (see section 5).

⁹ Derrida (1967) complained that Husserl did not take the distinction between linguistic meaning and intuitive knowledge far enough. Language was important for Husserl (it shaped thought), but not important enough, and private intuition kept the ruling role. Wittgenstein and Anscombe, on the other hand, attributed overriding importance to language, and left no knowing capacity for private intuition. To know what I think, I need to listen to what I say: this idea is common to Derrida and Wittgenstein. There are many other analogies between the two thinkers (see Staten 1985).

¹⁰ Whenever we become unable to read an ancient language, we lose at the same time the texts' meaning and their authors' intentions.

¹¹ Eco (1990) calls this *intentio lectoris*. For example, if my wife tells me that she's going to buy some cigarettes, and I believe this to be a subliminal message and that she will never return, very often I am just reading in the words something that is not there. A reference to the situation of utterance, and to our life in general, would be the only way to guide interpretation (in fact, every sentence is *potentially* ambiguous, but not all are *intentionally* ambiguous; see Eco's *openness*).

¹² Compagnon (1998) believes that Eco's *intentio operis* is just another way of talking about texts (against the complete freedom accorded to the reader by deconstruction) without including their authors. But Eco's pragmatic theory of interpretation could not do without the author's *intentions, strategies and choices*. The *intentio operis* is Eco's proper way to define a purely semiotic intention, existing only *in operari* and not *in mentis*.

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